

Digital Marketing Strategy and Implementation Plan for Aesop

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Abstract

This report presents a digital marketing strategy for Aesop. Its core challenge is a structural paradox: it possesses exceptional content and community assets while lacks fundamental digital infrastructure. Critically a 58 per cent unidentifiable online visitor rate that blocks personalization and retargeting. The strategy, structured around the RACE framework with priority on the Act and Engage phases, addresses these gaps through three interrelation initiatives: an AI-powered 'Fragrance Synesthete' tool that recreates sensory consultation online while capturing consent-based customer data; behavioral retargeting constrained by sensory-led creative to preserve brand trust; and 'Sensory Diaries', a monthly audio dispatch that systematizes Aesop's episodic earned-media success into a permanent loyalty loop. SMART objectives include raising identifiable online customers from 42 to 70 per cent, securing 25 per cent share of voice on non-branded search terms, and increasing organic amplification by 30 per cent.

Situation Analysis

◆ SWOT Analysis

Aesop's core tension can be distilled as follows: its strengths are almost entirely rooted in the offline and the analogue which are precisely assets difficult to acquire in the digital age. Meanwhile, its weaknesses are equally acute: 58 per cent of its online orders come from unidentifiable visitors (Cameron, 2024), its e-commerce site lacks personalized recommendations, and the global digital experience remains inconsistent. External opportunities, including rising online penetration in prestige beauty and room for expansion in Asia. Additionally post-pandemic demand for self-care continues to rise, with social platforms amplifying ‘slow living’ aesthetics (Bhardwaj, 2024), which aligns organically with Aesop’s philosophy. Threats, such as competitors like Le Labo offering more mature digital experiences and heightened consumer scrutiny of greenwashing, further widen this gap. Besides, EU’s General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and China’s Personal Information Protection Law constrain Aesop’s aggressive data collection and retargeting.

Internal—positive Strengths	Internal—negative Weaknesses
◆ Distinctive brand philosophy ◆ World-class sensory retail ◆ Resonant content narrative ◆ Access to L’Oréal resources	◆ 58% of online orders unidentifiable (Mi3, 2024) ◆ No e-commerce personalization ◆ Fragmented global ◆ Unbranded SEO absent ◆ Weak CRM
External—positive Opportunities	External—Negative Threats
◆ Turn psychological content into permanent digital tools ◆ Use L’Oréal AI to build a warm sensory recommendation engine ◆ Capture self-care search moments via content SEO at the Zero Moment of Truth	◆ Le Labo offers mature digital-to-physical experience ◆ Consumer scrutiny of brand authenticity may turn intrusive digital growth into backlash ◆ Aggressive retargeting risks contradicting Aesop’s ethos

Table 1: SWOT Strategic Implication Matrix for Aesop's Digital Marketing

◆ Digital Presence and Critical Evaluation

Owned Media

Aesop's brand website is its strongest owned-media asset. Product pages describe formulations and fragrance textures in prose reminiscent of literary essays, transforming browsing into a quiet reading experience.

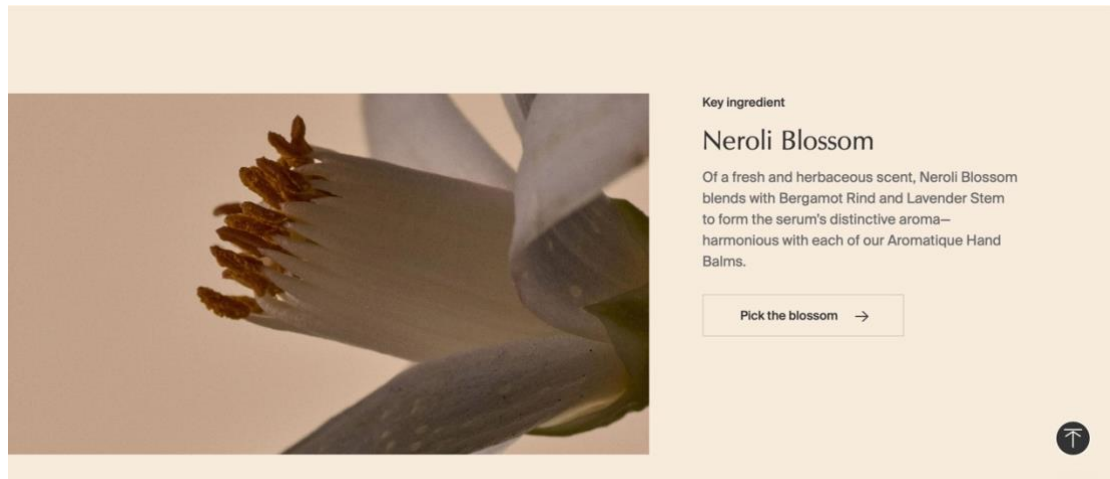


Figure 1 Detail Introduction in Aesop's product

Aesop's most distinctive owned-media asset in official website is not a campaign but a permanent architectural feature of its website "Library". Unlike conventional brand content hubs, the Aesop Library houses a collection of literary essays, author interviews, film recommendations, and podcast episodes. Crucially, virtually none of

which mention Aesop products directly.

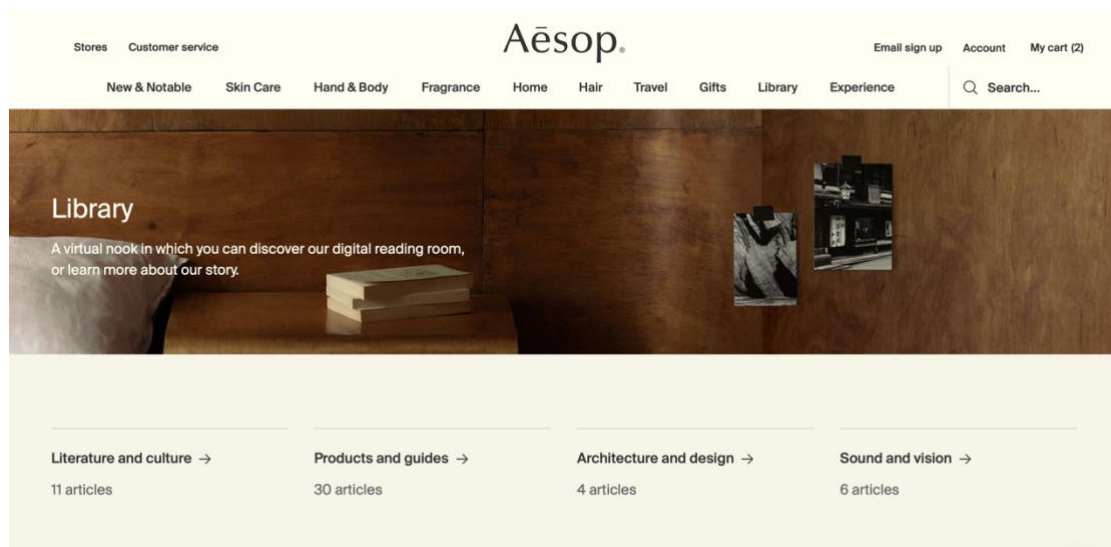


Figure 2 Aesop Library webpage

Additionally, the Library pages carry subtle links to relevant products, an essay on bathing routine quietly connects to body care product. This is not conventional content marketing but the construction of a cultural gravitational field. Which means Aesop attracts consumers by becoming an intellectual and aesthetic destination for its audience, making the commercial transaction feel almost incidental.

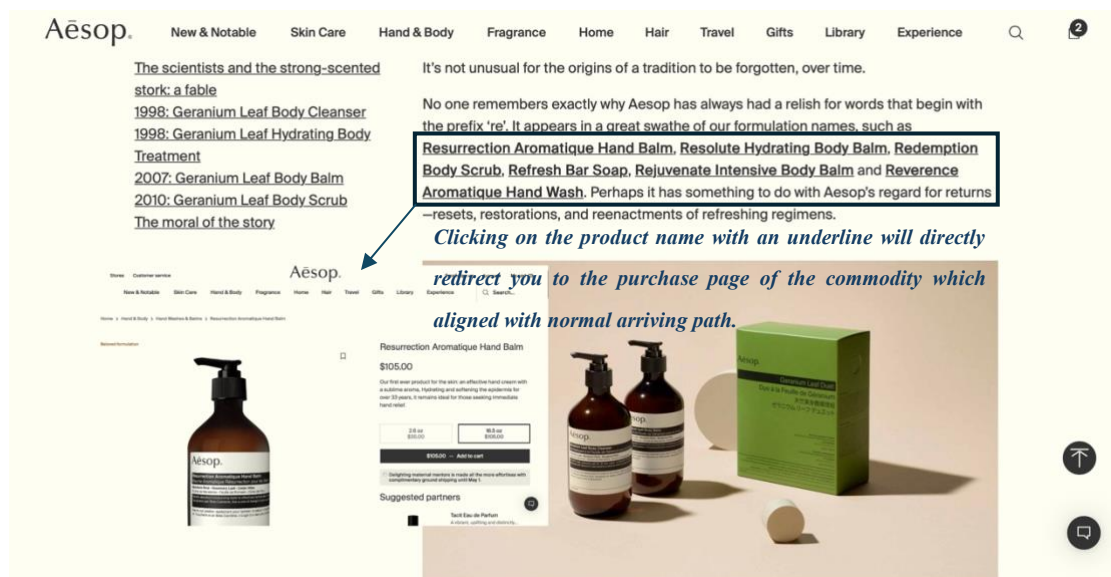


Figure 3 A Literature about Bathroom Product

Therefore, it remains a gap between the content layer and the transactional interface. E-commerce product pages are visually elegant. However, they lack personalized recommendations, sensory guidance tools, or any meaningful connection back to the “Library” content. A user arriving at a product page via a Library essay is the same as a user arriving via a paid search advertisement for ‘luxury hand wash’. The cost gained per customer through literature content is unknown, which fail to fully use cultural resources.

Le Labo, by contrast, has closed this gap more effectively: its laboratory-styled website mirrors its in-store experience, and its ‘City Exclusive fragrance’ online reservation system translates sensory discovery into a seamless digital transaction, demonstrating that the bridge Aesop lacks is both technically feasible and commercially valuable.

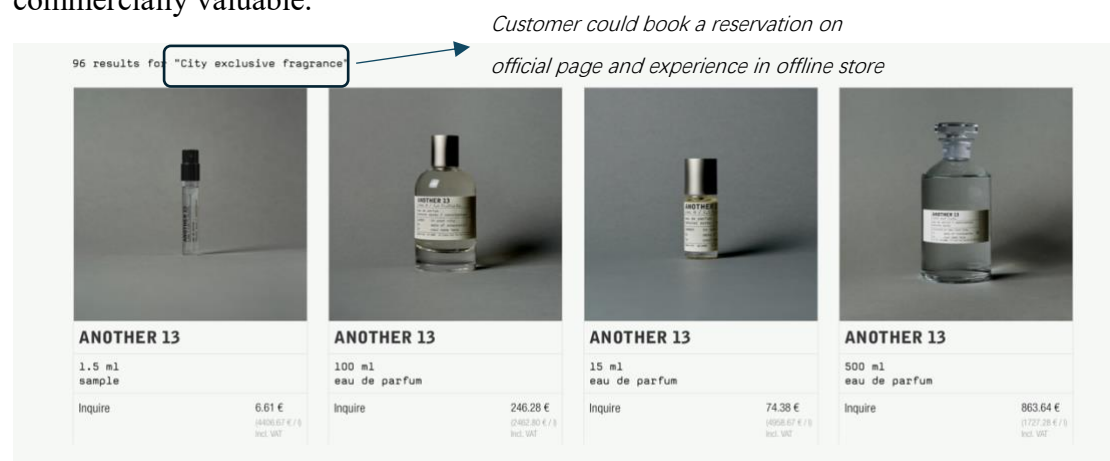


Figure 4 Official Webpage in Le Labo

Paid Media

Since joining the L’Oréal ecosystem, Aesop has introduced Partnerize for data-driven affiliate marketing, achieving a 14.46% increase in revenue and a 10.48% uplift in average order value (Partnerize, 2025). This confirms that modest data-driven intervention can significantly improve conversion efficiency.

Despite this, coverage of unbranded search terms remains invisible. Ahn et al., (2024) provide empirical evidence that a significant proportion of consumers use terms containing no brand name. When consumers search for ‘designer hand wash’ or ‘minimalist scent’, what De Brauwere (2025) terms as “stealth intent markers”, it

emerges at the end of the Zero Moment of Truth, when customers are ready to purchase (Lecinski, 2011). Aesop's absence from these queries means the brand is invisible when consumers are forming brand preferences. This high-intent traffic is instead intercepted by multi-brand retailers such as Sephora.

Earned Media

Aesop's "Women's Library" campaign represents its strongest earned-media asset. By converting stores into free book-sharing spaces, the initiative generated over 2.45 million views on social media and distributed more than 23,000 books (Jing Daily, 2024). Berger (2013) contagion framework explains this effectiveness: the campaign's non-commercial generosity created high social currency and emotional resonance, motivating consumers to share content. The initiative demonstrates how luxury brands can generate earned exposure by enabling experiential (User Generate Content) UGC co-creation (Scholz, 2014), consumers willingly become brand amplifiers when given moments worth sharing.

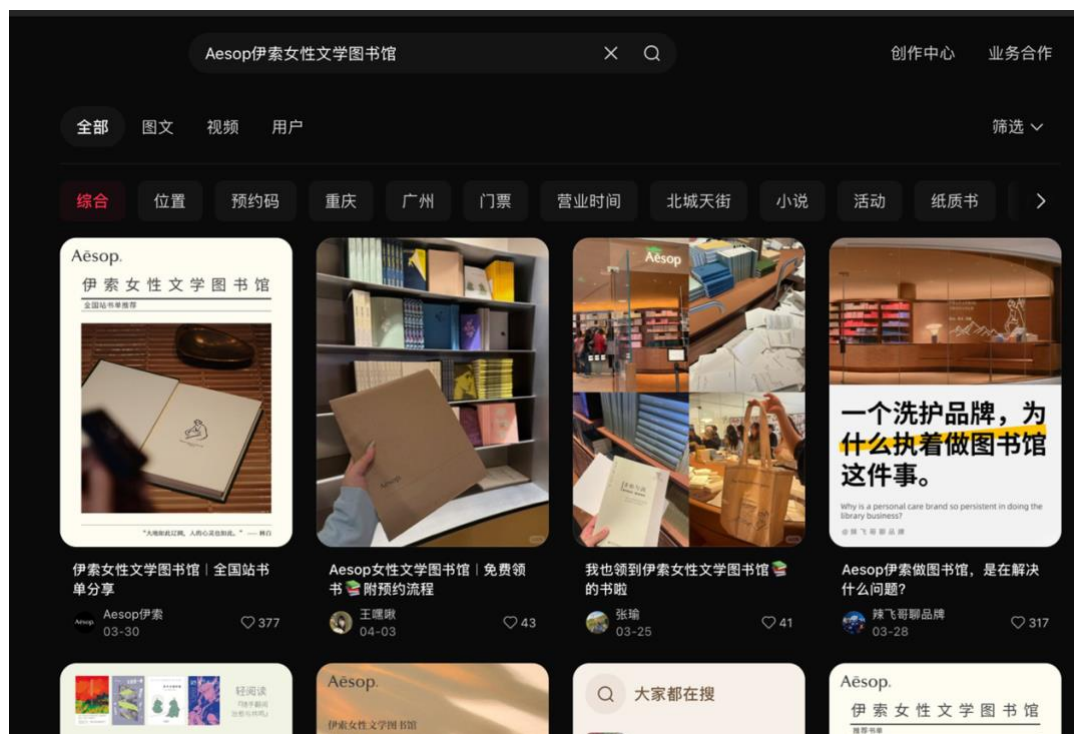


Figure 5 Posts on Rednote about Aesop Woman's Library Campaign

However, Aesop does not systematically repurpose the user-generated content it already possesses. Research consistently shows that UGC is a stronger predictor of

purchase decisions than influencer-generated content, as consumers perceive peer content as more authentic (Tang et al., 2014). By failing to fully utilize those earned media, Aesop lacks social proof which is a fundamental driver of online buyer behaviors (Sanak-Kosmowska, 2023).

A contrasting case is Lululemon, whose brand community overlaps significantly with Aesop's in its emphasis on lifestyle and well-being, yet whose approach to earned media yields markedly different acquisition outcomes. Central to Lululemon's model is a distinctive loop: it treats user-generated material not as incidental endorsement but as a structured asset with measurable commercial return. Aesop, by contrast, produces earned media of comparable aesthetic quality but treats it as cultural by-product: the content exists, circulates and fades without being captured, curated or redirected toward acquisition. The difference is not audience disposition but institutional design.

Marketing Objectives

All objectives are organized using the 5S model (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2023).

Sell

Increase the proportion of identifiable online customers from 42% to 70% within 12 months. The 58% unidentifiable visitor rate blocks all downstream personalization, retargeting, and CRM activity. This target addresses the root infrastructure problem before chasing revenue.

Speak

Achieve a 25 per cent share of voice on 20 priority non-branded category search terms within 9 months. Situation Analysis finds that Aesop is entirely absent from the high-intent search queries that define the Zero Moment of Truth.

Serve

Launch a 'Fragrance Synesthete' interactive online consultation tool on all primary market websites within 6 months, achieving a 20% click-through rate from product listing pages. Since Aesop remains untranslated in-store expertise to digital, the tool enables consent-based preference data collection that directly supports the Sell objective.

Sizzle

Increasing organic impression rate (shares, saves, reposts per post) by 30% across Instagram and Rednote within 12 months. The Women's Library campaign proved Aesop's latent shareability, which currently goes untapped between campaigns. This converts episodic earned media into systematic community propagation.

Digital Marketing Strategy and Implementation

The strategy focused on two priority phases of the RACE framework: Act and Engage.

◆ Target Audience

Aesop's defined primary audience is the thoughtful sensory consumer aged 25-40, urban, design-conscious, and with fundamental literacy. Target customer discovers products through editorial content, peer recommendations, and physical store experiences rather than promotional advertising. The positioning that guides all tactical execution is that Aesop is a gentle and eruditely partner, transforming daily routine into a sensory and intellect enjoy moment.

◆ Act

The Act phase is the strategic part of this plan, addressing the Serve and Sell objectives concurrently. Therefore, Act receives the highest budget allocation at approximately 40 per cent of total digital marketing spend, with tool "Fragrance

Synesthete” development commencing in month one and full global rollout targeted for month six. The “Fragrance Synesthete” interactive tool to achieve a 20% click-through rate from product listing pages and rising the identifiable online customer proportion from 42% to 70%. It is a web-based interactive consultation embedded on product listing page, landing pages, and the homepage. Users are guided to answer a sequence of sensory-preference questions: Warm textures or cool? Sunlight or Shadow? Morning rituals or evening stillness? After that, the tool will generate a personalized recommend product with a poetic narrative written in Aesop’s style. In the end, the user is invited to receive the recommendation via email, which can deepen the connect with customers.

Underpinning this tool is AI Marketing, its recommendation engine is powered by a collaborative filtering algorithm that matches users’ sensory preference vectors with product fragrance tags, continuously increase accuracy as data accumulates. However, this logic unlike typical retailer brands or L’Oréal-owned brands’ AI skin diagnostics, Aesop’s version deliberately avoids the visual language of scientific diagnosis. What the users see is a narrative, not a report, which is algorithm-driven in function, but literature driven in experience. This deliberate design choice is rooted in research which suggests that AI-powered service encounters must be carefully calibrated to the brand's relational style to avoid depersonalization (Huang & Rust, 2021).

This mechanism performs multi-function. Firstly, it transforms Aesop’s signature in-store sensory consultation into digital experience, which compensate the competitive weakness compared with Le Labo. Secondly, it creates an ethical path to grab personal data. Users voluntarily disclose identity and preference data to gain genuine value, directly advancing the Sell objective of doubling identifiable customers. Lastly, the accumulated sensory preference data will help Aesop to build unique classification system, product recommendation, CRM segmentation and new product development. It cost six months to implement tool under the coordination of the digital product team. User experience design and prototyping occupy first month to third month with roughly a quarter of the Act budget, while parallel algorithm development runs through first to fourth months, costing approximately 30% of resources allocation.

Front-end build and content management system integration follow across third to fifth months at 20% of budget, with user testing in fifth to sixth month cost 10% budget. After testing, Aesop can rollout globally in sixth month with 5% budget. Finally, it comes to email nurture sequence development. Users upon signing up via the tool, they will receive personalized email based on their previously indicated preferences. For example, a user who explored citrus notes reads a narrative fragment about bergamot harvest season; one drawn to woody notes receives a story of cedar and ancient libraries. This is an extension of AI marketing into the email channel where achieves scaled personalization in a form befitting Aesop rather than a product grid (Kumar et al., 2024).

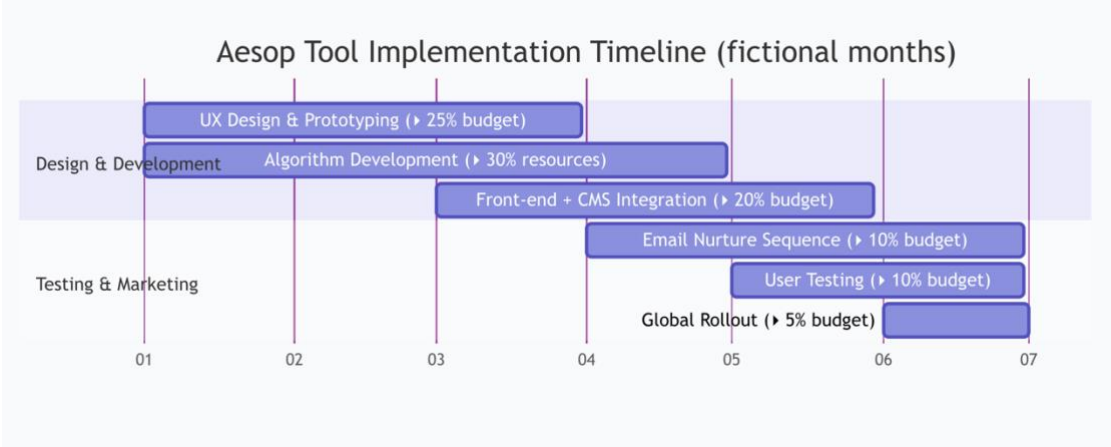


Table 2 Aesop Tool Implementation Timeline

◆ Engage

The Engage phase addresses the Sizzle objective of achieving a thirty percent increase in organic content amplification rate and receives approximately 25% of total budget. Preparatory work begins in month four, with full launch in month seven coinciding with the availability of identifiable customers from the Act phase, and ongoing monthly production thereafter.

From Situation Analysis about Earned Media, Aesop gained impressions episodic not systematic through Women’s Library campaign, which creates over two million impressions with low cost. However, majority of Users Generate Contents are not

fully be used. Therefore, “Engage phase” tend to build permanent, low-friction infrastructure to translate one-off campaign into a continuous cycle of community co-creation and content amplification. The central is “Sensory Diaries” which is a monthly audio newsletter. It is similar in form to a short narrative podcast episode and is sent only to identified customers. Each issues contains a brief narrative essay, a product ceremony suggestion, and an open-ended invitation to share one of your sensory moments of this month with activity tags. Aesop will select a portion of the submission, sign the names of the original authors, and repost them on its official Instagram or Rednote.

The purpose of reposting is not to pursue a bestseller. Contradict to nowadays majority of social contents which are chasing high-arousal viral spread, “Sensory Diaries” attempts to evoke a quiet emotion that makes customer stop and think. What can be shared by users as having personal significance exactly indicated with a contemplative quality (Berger, 2013). This kind of “low arousal” resonance is precisely what Aesop’s user are willing to actively spread.

Meanwhile, Aesop needs people to know this work exists not merely content alone. However, hard-sell advertising and buying reach through paid media mismatch its brand style. It is advisable to shape Sensory Diaries into something that is genuinely worth covering through public relations. For example, the PR team will invite lifestyle editors, cultural journalists, and podcast hosts to contribute to special themed edition. With these contributors on board, the teams will then approach for culturally aligned media whose readership closely overlaps with Aesop’s target audience. The logic underpinning this approach is drawn from Scott’s (2022) model of the brand as publisher. When a brand consistently produce content that holds genuine editorial value, public relations shifts from pushing stories onto journalists to pulling their interest. “Sensory Diaries” converts episodic media exposure into a stable pipeline of no-cost editorial coverage.

Additionally, Aesop’s physical stores remain its most powerful brand asset. It is

wisely to combine offline and online shopping experience. A single post-purchase email send automatically 48 hours after an in-store transaction, asks a deliberately oblique question: “What did you notice on the walk home?” This question does not ask for answers, but naturally triggered customers recall a sensory fragment.

View together, the three layers form a self-replenishing loop. A customer encounters a ‘Sensory Diaries’ and become intrigued by Aesop. After offline experience, they notice something and replies to the email. A month later, the response repost in official media and heard by more people. Ultimately the closed-loop system constructed in the Engage phase forms a Consumer Decision Journey (CDJ) (Court et al, 2009) shown in figure. “Sensory Diaries” becomes authentic content that influence new customers active evaluation. For contributors themselves, seeing reposted post-purchase experience reinforce their loyalty. Through this mechanism, Aesop successfully transforms a single transaction into a sustained loyalty loop, ensuring the brand no longer relies on one-off advertising campaigns but populates the ZMOT with continuous user narrative.

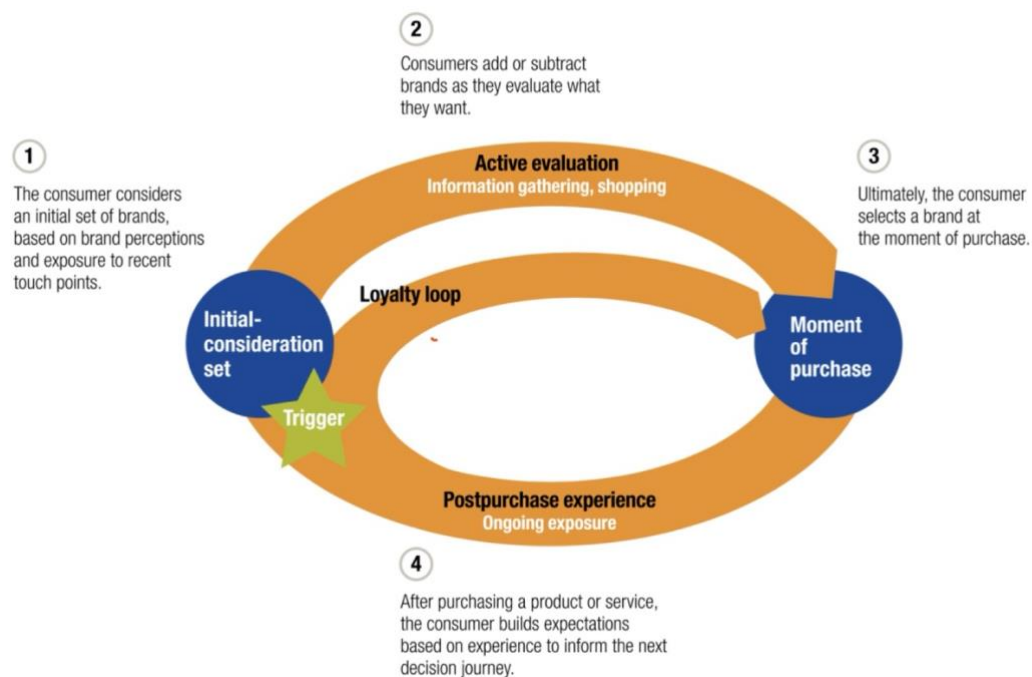


Figure 6 Consumer Decision Journey (Court et al., 2009)

Operationally, audio production setup will take place during fourth month to sixth

month including selecting a host, establishing recording and editing workflows, and producing a pilot batch of three episodes. This work will cost 25% of Engage budget. After that, the editorial team invite one guest writer per month to write a narrative at roughly 20% of the phase budget. Meanwhile, editorial team also need to select suitable customer feedback.

Performance Measurement

The performance measurement framework is structured around the four stages of RACE model.

◆ Act

The Act stage is the most critical measurement zone in this plan. The primary metric for Serve dimension is the click-through rate from product listing pages and the homepage into the tool, with a target of twenty percent established in the objective. Through analyze on-site data, it can measure whether the value proposition is compelling enough to draw users in.

The primary metric for the Sell dimension is the identifiable contact conversion rate. The proportion of tool users who complete the full questionnaire and voluntarily submit their email address to receive the personalized recommendation reflect whether the tool and value exchange at the point of email capture is persuasive enough. Additionally, further Act-stage diagnostic metrics include time spent interacting with the tool, which reveals whether the sensory-preference questions are engaging rather than randomly choose. Meanwhile, dividing the Act phase budget by the number of email addresses capture calculates the cost of per identifiable lead, which allows managers to compare efficiency in marketing campaign.

◆ Engage

The Engage Stage measures the success in transforming purchasers into brand advocates, directly serving the Sizzle objective of a 30% increase in organic amplification rate. It can be measured through the number of shares, saves, and user-generated repost per post, divided by total impressions. Those numbers provide insight into the effectiveness of the “Sensory Diaries” ecosystem. A flat or declining trajectory after the first three months suggests that the initiative’s creative framing or incentive structure needs refreshing. Meanwhile, the number of brand’s mentions across social platforms captures the boarder earned media effect. The repurchase rate among identified customers who have engage with “Sensory Diaries” content is tracked as a long-lasting indicator of whether the community infrastructure is deepening loyalty, not merely generating noise.

Conclusion and Strategic Recommendations

The central finding of this report is that Aesop’s digital gap is not a technological shortfall but an experiential one. The brand already owns a dense sensory language, deep community trust, and a store experience that people travel to visit. What it lacks is the infrastructure to translate these assets into the moments when consumers make decisions online. The strategy set out in this report therefore does not bolt digital tactics onto an analogue brand; it extends the brand’s existing logic “quiet, literary, consent-based” into the digital journey, using AI and data not to accelerate the hard sell but to recreate online the unhurried, knowledgeable consultation that made Aesop distinctive in the first place. In doing so, it transforms the brand’s most conspicuous weakness, the 58 per cent unidentifiable visitor rate into a deliberate mechanism for gathering data through genuine service rather than passive tracking.

Aesop fulfil this window through brand-owned, and community generate narrative by permanent infrastructure. The Consumer Decision Journey model (Court et al., 2009) further validates the Engage phase's loyalty loop, positioning post-purchase

experience not as a transactional endpoint but as the beginning of the next consideration cycle.

Three priorities should guide Aesop beyond this plan. Firstly, how to completely utilize the data collect through “Fragrance Synesthete”? Those data should be developed into a proprietary data asset informing product development, not merely marketing personalization. Which is a capability no competitor currently possesses at scale. Secondly, “Sensory Diaries” should mature from a monthly audio dispatch into a fully realized brand publishing division encompassing print editions and cultural collaborations, deepening Aesop's positioning as a cultural contributor. From another perspective, the cooperation with print editions not only promotion the Aesop’s unique corporates culture but also attracting leads offline. Third, as L'Oréal integrates Aesop into its broader digital ecosystem, brand leadership must vigilantly protect the aesthetic and ethical boundaries that distinguish Aesop from its parent group's other luxury brands, resisting pressure to adopt higher-frequency performance marketing tactics.

Two principal risks require sustainable attention. The privacy paradox embedded in the Act phase means any perception of surveillance rather than service would cause disproportionate brand damage, given that trust constitutes Aesop's most valuable intangible asset; all data collection must therefore maintain the highest standard of consent clarity. Regarding resource prioritization, the 'Fragrance Synesthete' and its email nurture constitute the non-negotiable core, as all downstream capabilities depend on first establishing an identifiable customer base. “Sensory Diaries” is the next priority, building on Aesop's strongest existing asset. The non-branded search content hub and paid search supplement should be the first activities scaled back under budget constraints.

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